MONTHLY UPDATE

Lesotho: monthly update, September – October 2026

Edition of 2026-10-16-2 · compiled by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository

> *Developments reported in sources published between the beginning of last month and today, grouped by story, oldest first.*

STATUS · PROGRESS · INSTITUTION HOSTING

GOVERNANCE
Legislation and regulation · Data protection · Regional collaboration

ICT INFRASTRUCTURE
Connectivity · Data Storage

DPI
Data Exchange · Digital Payments and Fintech · Registries · Other GovTech and e-Gov

TECHNOLOGY
AI

CAPACITY
Training and skills

DATA
National statistics

Governance

Legislation and regulation

CYBERSECURITY BILL

- **Stakeholders Engage on Cybersecurity Bill 2026** — Government of Lesotho — Department of Information, 23 September 2026

  Lesotho's information and communications ministry, with the Lesotho Communications Authority and UNDP, held a two-day consultation on the Cybersecurity Bill 2026 in Maseru, reported on 23 September 2026. Cabinet split the 2024 Computer Crime and Cybersecurity Bill into separate cybercrime and cybersecurity bills; the new bill proposes a two-tier regulatory regime and registration of cybersecurity professionals.

ELECTRONIC TRANSACTIONS AND COMMUNICATIONS BILL (2022 BILL, REVISED 2026)

- **MICSTI ON ELECTRONIC TRANSACTIONS, COMMUNICATIONS BILL** — Government of Lesotho, 29 September 2026

  Lesotho's information and communications ministry held a two-day validation workshop in Maseru from 28 September 2026 on the Electronic Transactions and Communications Bill, 2026, supported by UNDP. The bill would give legal recognition to electronic contracts, signatures and records and is aligned with the revised SADC framework; the ministry says Lesotho has no law on electronic transactions.

- **Lesotho revises electronic transactions bill** — ITWeb Africa, 30 September 2026

> Lesotho's ICT ministry held a two-day validation workshop with UNDP on the Electronic Transactions and Communications Bill 2026, a revision of the 2022 bill, to fill the absence of any legal framework for electronic contracts, signatures and records. The bill now moves to the next legislative stages.

Data protection

> DPI SAFEGUARDS FOR CHILDREN

- **Ramashamole Champions Safe Digital Public Infrastructure at UNGA81** — Government of Lesotho — Department of Information / Lesotho News Agency, 23 September 2026

  Lesotho's ICT ministry has developed safeguards for children in digital public infrastructure with UNICEF Lesotho and is piloting them with the National University of Lesotho across five ministries, Principal Secretary Kanono Ramashamole told side meetings at the 81st UN General Assembly. He also spoke on financing, total cost of ownership and procurement of digital public infrastructure.

Regional collaboration

> SMART ONE-STOP BORDER POSTS WITH SOUTH AFRICA AT MASERU AND FICKSBURG

- **Lesotho-South Africa Bi-National Commission (BNC) Mid-term Review Concludes in Pretoria** — Government of Lesotho (via APO Group), 10 September 2026 SOUTH AFRICA

  Lesotho and South Africa concluded a mid-term review of their Bi-National Commission in Pretoria on 9 September 2026 after three days of talks. Outcomes included faster work on Smart One-Stop Border Posts at Maseru and Ficksburg, progress on a new migration model for labour mobility, and Phase II of the Lesotho Highlands Water Project. The next full session is set for South Africa in 2027.

> COMMUNICATIONS REGULATORS' MEMORANDUM WITH ESWATINI

- **Eswatini, Lesotho Join Forces to Tackle Cyber Threats** — Eswatini Positive News, 7 October 2026 ESWATINI

  The Eswatini Communications Commission and the Lesotho Communications Authority signed a memorandum of understanding on 3 October 2026 covering information exchange, joint research, staff development and cybersecurity cooperation, including coordinated incident response, awareness campaigns, training and audits. No budget or timetable is given.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

> STARLINK SATELLITE INTERNET SERVICE

- **Vodacom Lesotho Launches Enterprise Satellite Connectivity Solution Powered by Starlink** — Space in Africa, 9 October 2026

  Vodacom Lesotho launched a managed satellite internet service for businesses and institutions built on Starlink, at an event in Maseru reported on 9 October 2026. It offers primary connectivity where there are no terrestrial networks, a backup option, and a combined satellite and terrestrial mode. Target sectors include financial services, health, education and public administration; no prices are given.

Data Storage

> HYDROPOWER AND AI DATA CENTRE AGREEMENT

- **Lesotho's biggest foreign investment deal faces scrutiny** — Daily Maverick, 15 September 2026

The country signed a US$6.2bn agreement, its largest recorded foreign investment, for a hydropower plant and artificial intelligence data centre. A feasibility study runs over the next year, then implementation agreements including water-use plans, and a potential conflict of interest has surfaced.

- **Minister may benefit from Lesotho's R100-billion AI and hydropower deal** — GroundUp, 15 September 2026

  The public works minister holds shares in a firm the energy minister named among potential local partners for the country's US$6.2bn artificial intelligence and hydropower project. He has previously been accused of conflict of interest.

DPI

Data Exchange

NATIONAL SINGLE WINDOW

- **Public-Private Dialogue reforms stalled in nine areas, Matekane says** — Lesotho Tribune, 27 September 2026

  Lesotho's prime minister, Sam Matekane, told a public-private dialogue forum in May 2026 that nine agreed reforms had not started or were awaiting Cabinet, according to a World Bank-funded project newsletter reported on 27 September. The same newsletter says the National Single Window operates without its own law and the central bank is still building a government e-payment gateway.

Digital Payments and Fintech

VOUCHER-FREE ELECTRONIC AIRTIME

- **Vodacom launches voucher-free airtime service** — Lesotho Times, 4 September 2026

  Vodacom Lesotho launched Dynamic Airtime in the week of 4 September 2026, letting customers buy airtime electronically in any amount from M1.50 instead of using fixed-value physical vouchers. Vendors enter the customer's number and amount and confirm the name registered to the SIM before the airtime is credited.

WHOLE-OF-GOVERNMENT E-PAYMENT GATEWAY

- **Public-Private Dialogue reforms stalled in nine areas, Matekane says** — Lesotho Tribune, 27 September 2026

  Summarised under Data Exchange.

Registries

NATIONAL ADDRESS REGISTER

- **Kenya and Lesotho Deepen ICT Regulatory Cooperation on National Addressing System** — Tech Africa News, 2 September 2026 KENYA

  Kenya's Communications Authority is hosting a Lesotho Communications Authority delegation to benchmark Kenya's National Addressing System and the legal framework behind it. Kenya's system is designed to give every street, building and parcel of land a verifiable address, supporting last-mile e-commerce delivery and emergency response, and the authority has driven the draft National Addressing System Bill, 2025 with standards developed jointly with the Kenya Bureau of Standards. No visit dates are stated.

- **LESOTHO GOVERNMENT IS POISED TO BENEFIT SIGNIFICANTLY FROM WORLD BANK AS IT'S ON A VITAL MISSION TO TACKLE YOUTH UNEMPLOYMENT THROUGH INNOVATIVE DIGITAL PUBLIC WORKS PROGRAMS. - Government of Lesotho** — Government of Lesotho, 12 October 2026

A World Bank urban and land team told Lesotho's communications ministry it is interested in supporting a nationwide digital address system, in talks that also covered geospatial data for planning and digital public works for young people. No commitment or amount was stated.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

NATIONAL DATA VALUE CREATION BLUEPRINT

- **The Government of Lesotho tabled a National Data Value Creation Blueprint draft to position Lesotho competitively on the international digital landscape** — Government of Lesotho (sourced from Lesotho News Agency, LENA), 16 September 2026

  Lesotho's Ministry of Information, Communications, Science, Technology and Innovation presented a draft National Data Value Creation Blueprint for validation at a workshop in Maseru, reported on 16 September 2026. Participants reviewed its strategic framework, priority use cases and required infrastructure, with three to five flagship use cases to be selected. The Smart Africa Digital Academy is guiding the work; the draft itself is not published.

- **Lesotho makes history** — Lesotho Times, 17 September 2026

  Lesotho became the first country to validate a Smart Africa Data Value Creation Blueprint, at a workshop in Maseru convened by its ICT ministry with Smart Africa and GIZ. An accompanying diagnostic calls the country's data ecosystem emerging but fragmented, rates data quality, access and interoperability weakest of five dimensions, and lists 11 priority gaps.

Technology

AI

NATIONAL COMPUTE ROADMAP 2026-2029

- **Lesotho First Country to Implement UN AI Blueprint** — Government of Lesotho — Department of Information, 23 September 2026

  Lesotho's prime minister, Samuel Matekane, told the second UN Digital Cooperation Day in New York that Lesotho is the first country to implement the UN AI Blueprint. He said planning is complete and Phase One of a National Compute Roadmap for 2026 to 2029 has begun, after more than a year of assessing compute, data-centre, connectivity, skills and financing needs. No cost is given.

Capacity

Training and skills

SMART AFRICA DIGITAL ACADEMY IN LESOTHO

- **LESOTHO JOINED A CONTINENTAL ALLIANCE TO ADVANCE AI, DATA AND DIGITAL SKILLS PAVING THE WAY FOR THE ESTABLISHMENT OF THE SMART AFRICA DIGITAL ACADEMY. - Government of Lesotho** — Government of Lesotho, 12 October 2026

  Lesotho's communications minister took part in the 21st Smart Africa Alliance meeting, and government said efforts are under way to establish the alliance's digital academy in the country. Lesotho joined the alliance in 2025.

Data

National statistics

GIS FINANCIAL ACCESS POINTS MAPPING

- **Consultancy - Data Collection and Analytics for Lesotho GIS Financial Access Points Mapping Project – Phase 2** — Selibeng.com (FinMark Trust terms of reference), 13 September 2026

  FinMark Trust issued terms of reference for Phase 2 of Lesotho's GIS Financial Access Points Mapping Project, to update a 2018 baseline of 5,597 geo-referenced access points. The work covers every mobile-money agent, bank branch, ATM and post office across ten districts, with spatial analytics and a web map.

POPULATION AND HOUSING CENSUS

- **"We felt like part of the Basotho": Census gives LGBTIQ+ community a place in national data** — Public Eye, 17 September 2026

  Lesotho's 2026 census asked questions recognising gender identity and sexuality for the first time, after the statistics bureau brought an advocacy organisation into the first consultation. The round had a reference night of 11 April, employed more than 8,000 temporary field staff and has finished enumeration with mop-up still running in Maseru; advocates welcomed the inclusion while warning that the answers need explicit privacy and confidentiality safeguards.

ABOUT THIS DOCUMENT

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